

WHERE THEY STAND

Product architecture, research workflow, coding plan, design system, neutrality rules, and launch handoff

Core promise

We do not tell voters what to believe. We show what candidates have actually said, what evidence supports the classification, and where each voter agrees or disagrees.

PRODUCT RULE

No candidate is scored as better or worse. No position is treated as correct. Every classification must be traceable to public evidence.

Prepared as a coding handoff. This document assumes a nationwide 2026 U.S. House and Senate candidate database, with candidate positions tracked across 15 defined legislative concepts.

Handoff map

Section	Contents
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03	The 15 issue framework
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05	Candidate and race data acquisition
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BUILD TARGET

A voter should be able to enter an address, see the federal races on that ballot, compare candidates across 15 fixed questions, inspect the source for every stance, and measure personal agreement without receiving an endorsement.

01. Product definition and non-negotiables

Where They Stand is a public, nonpartisan candidate-position database and voter comparison tool. It converts campaign platforms, official statements, public votes, and direct campaign responses into a small set of transparent stance labels tied to specific bill concepts.

What the product does

- Maintains a canonical list of federal races and candidates.
- Maintains exactly defined versions of 15 legislative concepts.
- Finds official public evidence for each candidate on each concept.
- Classifies the candidate's public position using a fixed rule set.
- Shows the evidence and source behind every published classification.
- Allows campaigns to submit corrections or official answers.
- Allows voters to state their own positions and compare agreement.
- Preserves historical changes when a candidate changes position.

What the product does not do

- Does not endorse candidates, parties, or positions.
- Does not infer a stance from party affiliation, donor history, endorsements, demographics, or geography.
- Does not publish ideological scores such as conservative, liberal, moderate, extreme, or electability.
- Does not use red-versus-blue visual language to signal approval or disapproval.
- Does not hide disagreement. A clear opposition stance is displayed with the same prominence as a clear support stance.
- Does not let an AI system publish a political classification without human verification.
- Does not treat silence as opposition. Silence is No Public Position Found.

NEUTRALITY TEST

If two candidates swapped parties but kept the exact same evidence, the system must produce the exact same classification and presentation.

Primary user outcomes

User	Job to be done	Success
Voter	Understand the candidates in my races quickly.	Can compare all candidates and inspect evidence in minutes.
Campaign	Make sure our positions are represented accurately.	Can submit an official response and source.
Editor	Research and verify positions consistently.	Can trace every label to evidence and an audit record.
Engineer	Operate a national data pipeline safely.	Can rerun collection, detect changes, and reproduce published state.

02. Voter experience and information architecture

Primary flow

1. Visitor lands on the home page and sees the product promise plus the 15 issue concepts.
2. Visitor enters a street address or chooses state and congressional district. The address is used only to resolve districts and is discarded by default.
3. System returns the federal contests relevant to that voter, normally U.S. House and applicable U.S. Senate contests.
4. Race page shows every ballot-qualified candidate with the same card size and ordering rule.
5. Comparison table shows one neutral stance label per issue, plus a View Evidence action.
6. Visitor can answer the same 15 questions and optionally mark up to five as most important.
7. System displays agreement counts and priority agreement. It never says which candidate the voter should choose.
8. Visitor can open any issue or candidate detail page and inspect source history.

Top-level navigation

Nav item	Purpose
Find My Races	Address or state/district lookup.
Compare Candidates	Direct race comparison.
The 15 Issues	Plain-language issue and bill concept pages.
Methodology	Neutrality rules, source hierarchy, classifications, corrections.
Candidate Index	Browse by state, office, district, or name.
Source Updates	Recent position changes and newly verified records.
About	Ownership, funding disclosure, editorial independence, contact.

Page map

- / - Home
- /find - Address and district lookup
- /race/{election}/{office}/{state}/{district} - Race comparison
- /candidate/{candidate-id} - Candidate profile and stance history
- /issue/{issue-slug} - Bill concept, goal, plan, exact classification question
- /compare/{race-id} - Interactive voter match mode
- /methodology - Classification and neutrality rules
- /corrections - Campaign and public correction intake
- /sources/{source-id} - Archived source metadata and provenance
- /admin/* - Authenticated research and editorial console

VOTER-FACING ORDER

Do not group the 15 questions under Republican, Democratic, or centrist headings on comparison screens. Use neutral subject categories and a fixed order for every race.

03. The 15 issue framework

Each issue is a versioned object. The question, goal, and bill concept must be frozen for a published election cycle. If the policy changes materially, create a new version rather than silently editing what a candidate was classified against.

Issue	Working bill concept	Goal	Canonical question
Housing Supply	Build America Homes Act	Increase housing supply by tying selected federal housing incentives to measurable local production.	Do you support federal incentives and conditions designed to increase local housing production?
Medical Price Disclosure	Price Before Care Act	Require a binding patient price before scheduled nonemergency care.	Do you support requiring a binding patient price before scheduled nonemergency care, with undisclosed covered charges generally uncollectible?
Immigration Reset	American Immigration Reset Act	Create a defined legal process for qualifying long-term residents and a firm enforcement line for future unlawful entry.	Do you support a one-time legal-status process for qualifying long-term residents paired with stricter future enforcement?
Congressional Stock Ownership	Public Service, Not Private Profit Act	Bar covered federal officials and immediate family from owning or trading individual stocks while in office.	Do you support barring covered federal elected officials and immediate family from owning or trading individual stocks while the official serves?
War Powers	War Vote Act	Require a recorded congressional vote before prolonged offensive military operations continue.	Do you support requiring a standalone congressional vote before prolonged offensive military operations continue?
Federal Voter ID	One Citizen, One Vote Act	Set federal identity and citizenship verification rules while requiring a free qualifying ID path.	Do you support photo ID for federal in-person voting and documentary citizenship verification for registration, with a free qualifying ID process?
Border Enforcement	Secure Border Standard Act	Set measurable federal border enforcement, adjudication, and employment verification requirements.	Do you support mandatory employment verification and increased federal detention, adjudication, and enforcement for unlawful entry, subject to due process?
Parental Authority in Schools	Parents Know Act	Set a parental notification and consent baseline for federally funded K-12 schools.	Do you support federal parental notice and consent requirements for specified

			school record and student-policy decisions?
Energy Permitting	American Energy Permit Act	Require timely federal decisions for major domestic energy infrastructure across technologies.	Do you support a two-year federal approve-or-deny deadline for covered major domestic energy projects?
Federal Funding for Minor Gender Procedures	Federal Funds for Minors Act	Restrict federal funding for specifically defined gender-transition procedures for minors.	Do you support restricting federal funding for the specifically defined procedures covered by this proposal for people under 18?
Federal Abortion Standard	National Reproductive Standard Act	Create a national statutory abortion-access floor before viability, with defined post-viability exceptions.	Do you support a federal law protecting abortion access before viability in every state?
Universal Health Coverage	American Health Guarantee Act	Guarantee baseline health coverage independent of employment.	Do you support government-guaranteed baseline health coverage for every U.S. citizen and qualifying lawful resident?
Firearm Background Checks	Every Sale Background Check Act	Require background checks for most firearm transfers with defined family and emergency exceptions.	Do you support requiring a federal background check for most firearm transfers, including most private sales?
Federal Voting Access Standards	American Voting Standard Act	Set minimum federal standards for early voting, mail voting, registration, and audits.	Do you support national minimum standards for early voting, mail voting, voter registration, and auditable federal elections?
High-Income and Corporate Minimum Tax	Minimum Contribution Act	Set an explicit minimum effective federal tax rate above defined high-income and corporate-profit thresholds.	Do you support a minimum effective federal tax rate for extremely high-income households and large profitable corporations above defined thresholds?

Important: final legal wording should be reviewed by election counsel and subject-matter counsel before publication. The site compares candidates against the published concept, not against a hypothetical full bill text.

04. Candidate stance model and evidence rules

Public stance labels

Label	Definition	User-facing meaning
SUPPORTS	Clear support for the canonical proposal	Candidate supports this proposal.

	or a materially equivalent policy.	
OPPOSES	Clear opposition to the canonical proposal or a materially equivalent policy.	Candidate opposes this proposal.
DIFFERENT APPROACH	Candidate addresses the same problem but supports a materially different mechanism, or supports only a major subset.	Candidate takes a different approach.
NO PUBLIC POSITION FOUND	Research completed without reliable evidence establishing a position.	No reliable public position found.
DECLINED TO STATE	Campaign was directly asked and explicitly declined or refused to answer.	Campaign declined to state a position.

Internal-only states

- PENDING RESEARCH - candidate/issue has not completed the research pass.
- PENDING REVIEW - evidence exists but a human has not approved the classification.
- CONFLICT - credible sources indicate inconsistent positions and the conflict is not yet resolved.
- STALE - last verified source is outside the configured recency window or source is no longer available.
- LEGAL HOLD - publication paused due to correction, identity, or legal review.

Evidence hierarchy

Priority	Source type	Rule
1	Direct campaign response	Best source. Store exact submitted answer, timestamp, submitter verification, and any supporting link.
2	Recorded federal vote	Strongest evidence for incumbents when the vote maps directly to the canonical proposal.
3	Official campaign platform	Candidate-owned policy page, issues page, press release, or official campaign document.
4	Official candidate statement	Speech, interview, debate, press conference, newsletter, or verified social account.
5	Government or legislative record	Congress.gov sponsorship, cosponsorship, committee record, or official government statement.
6	Credible reporting with direct attribution	Use only when the source quotes or clearly attributes the candidate's position.
7	No inference	Party platform, endorsements, donors, interest-group ratings, and demographic

		assumptions never establish the candidate's stance.
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Recency and conflicts

- Use the most recent explicit position when a candidate clearly changes position.
- Do not erase older evidence. Show a position history with dates.
- A more recent vague statement does not automatically override an older explicit statement.
- When two current sources conflict, publish Different Approach or hold for review until the campaign is contacted.
- For an incumbent, a recorded vote can outweigh campaign copy when the vote precisely maps to the proposal. The discrepancy should be shown, not hidden.

HARD RULE

Never translate party identity into a stance. A Republican or Democrat with no reliable evidence receives No Public Position Found.

05. Candidate and race data acquisition

Use government sources as the spine of the candidate registry. Treat third-party election databases as supplemental, not canonical.

Canonical source stack

Need	Primary source	Fallback or validation
Federal candidate identity	OpenFEC / FEC candidate records	State election authority candidate lists.
Ballot qualification	State secretary of state or state election authority	Google Civic Information during supported elections.
District and voter contest lookup	Google Civic Information API and/or official district geometry	State election authority; district shapefiles.
Incumbent legislative history	Congress.gov API	House/Senate official roll-call records where needed.
Candidate campaign website	FEC filings, campaign submission, search discovery	Manual verification.
Candidate official social accounts	Campaign website links, verified account metadata, campaign confirmation	Manual verification.

Candidate identity resolution

- Create one internal candidate UUID and map all external IDs to it, including FEC candidate ID, committee IDs, Congress member ID, state ballot ID, and social account IDs.
- Do not merge records solely on name. Require office, state, cycle, and at least one corroborating identity field.

- Support candidate renames, suffixes, withdrawn candidates, replacements, write-ins, special elections, and multi-cycle candidacies.
- Track ballot status separately from FEC filing status. Filing with the FEC does not by itself prove ballot qualification.
- Preserve withdrawn and disqualified records for audit, but hide them from the default active race view after official confirmation.

Race refresh cadence

Window	Refresh
Normal campaign period	Daily candidate registry check.
After filing deadlines / court decisions	Every 4 to 6 hours for affected states.
Final 30 days	At least twice daily for race metadata, plus source monitoring.
Election day window	Freeze policy classifications only if editorial staff chooses; race status and official links can continue updating.

06. Website and social research pipeline

Discovery before crawling

9. Resolve the official candidate website and official social accounts.
10. Verify account ownership using links from the candidate website, campaign submission, platform verification, or two independent identity signals.
11. Record robots.txt, sitemap locations, canonical URLs, and allowed crawl paths.
12. Prefer site maps, RSS feeds, public APIs, and platform-provided feeds before HTML crawling.
13. Create an allowlist per candidate. The research worker only collects from approved domains and approved account IDs.

Campaign website crawler

- Fetch robots.txt before crawling and respect disallow rules.
- Rate limit by domain and use conditional requests with ETag and Last-Modified where available.
- Start with sitemap.xml, issue pages, press/news pages, endorsements or policy PDFs, FAQ, and about pages.
- Use a bounded crawl depth and URL budget to prevent loops, calendars, donation funnels, and infinite parameters.
- Normalize URLs, strip tracking parameters, and deduplicate by canonical URL and content hash.
- Store extracted text, page title, source URL, retrieval timestamp, published timestamp when present, and a content hash.
- Archive a source snapshot or rendered evidence image only where permitted. Always retain enough metadata to reproduce the evidence trail.
- Do not bypass paywalls, authentication, CAPTCHAs, technical access controls, or platform restrictions.

Social and video collection

Platform	Preferred collection method	Implementation note
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X	Official X API when licensed for the required access.	Consumption-based API costs and terms can change. Build a provider adapter.
Facebook / Instagram	Meta Graph API where permissions permit public Page access.	Do not assume all public content is available through the API. Provide manual/source-search fallback.
YouTube	YouTube Data API for channels, uploads, video metadata; transcript/caption handling only where permitted.	Store video ID, timestamp range, and transcript provenance.
Bluesky	AT Protocol public APIs.	Use DID/account identity, not display name alone.
Candidate newsletters	Official RSS or campaign archive pages; email only when explicitly subscribed by the project.	Preserve message date and canonical archive URL when available.
Debates / interviews	Official broadcaster, campaign channel, government channel, or licensed/publicly available transcript.	Require candidate attribution and timestamp.

Search-assisted discovery

Search engines can locate candidate statements that the crawler missed. Search is discovery, not proof. The system must fetch and preserve the underlying source before a classification can be approved.

SCRAPING RULE

Build adapters around lawful, documented access. Do not design the product around unauthorized scraping of restricted social platforms.

07. AI extraction and human verification

AI should reduce research labor, not become the editorial authority. The system can retrieve, rank, summarize, and propose a stance, but a human reviewer approves any political classification that becomes public.

Research pipeline

14. Collector ingests new or changed candidate content.
15. Indexer splits text into source passages with stable source IDs and offsets.
16. Retriever runs 15 issue-specific search templates against each candidate corpus.
17. Extractor returns structured evidence candidates, not prose.
18. Classifier proposes Supports, Opposes, Different Approach, or Insufficient Evidence.
19. Rule engine checks source priority, date, directness, and contradictions.
20. Human reviewer sees evidence side by side and approves, changes, or rejects.
21. Publisher writes a versioned stance record and updates the public site.
22. Campaign correction system is notified when a new or changed stance is published, if campaign contact data is available.

Structured extraction contract

```
{
  "candidate_id": "uuid",
  "issue_version_id": "uuid",
  "proposed_stance": "SUPPORTS | OPPOSES | DIFFERENT_APPROACH | INSUFFICIENT",
  "evidence": [
    {
      "source_id": "uuid",
      "passage_start": 1024,
      "passage_end": 1288,
      "statement_date": "YYYY-MM-DD",
      "directness": "DIRECT | STRONGLY_EQUIVALENT | CONTEXT_ONLY",
      "reason": "Short neutral explanation"
    }
  ],
  "conflict_detected": false
}
```

Prompt and model rules

- Provide the canonical issue definition and exact question with every classification request.
- Require citation to source passage IDs. No source, no stance.
- Tell the model to classify only the candidate in question, not the party.
- Do not ask the model whether a position is good, bad, moderate, extreme, popular, or likely to win.
- Use deterministic structured output with a schema validator.
- Run contradiction detection across all high-priority evidence before sending to review.
- Retain the model name, prompt version, source IDs, and output for reproducibility.
- Never show AI confidence to voters as a substitute for evidence.

Human review screen

- Show the canonical question at the top.
- Show proposed stance and all cited passages.
- Show source type, source date, retrieval date, and source URL.
- Show conflicting evidence in the same view.
- Hide party label by default during stance review when practical.
- Require reviewer reason for overriding the model or a prior published classification.
- Two-person review for disputes, high-profile changes, or corrections alleging material error.

08. Corrections, disputes, and position changes

Campaign response program

Every campaign should receive the same invitation to answer the 15 canonical questions. Direct responses are published whether they support, oppose, or reject the site's framing.

- Verify campaign email or domain before accepting an answer as an official campaign response.
- Allow answer choices: Support, Oppose, Different Approach, Decline to State.
- Allow a short explanation and supporting source link.
- Store the exact submitted answer and the display summary separately.
- Do not rewrite a campaign's yes/no answer into a different stance unless the campaign response is internally contradictory. Escalate contradictions for review.

Correction workflow

23. Correction submitted by campaign or member of the public.
24. System creates immutable case ID and captures challenged stance/source.
25. Editor reviews source identity and evidence.
26. If clearly wrong, correct immediately and preserve revision history.
27. If disputed, request campaign source or clarification.
28. Second reviewer handles unresolved material disputes.
29. Publish correction note when the change was material.
30. Do not delete prior stance history unless it involved identity error, private data, or legal removal.

Position change display

EXAMPLE

CURRENT: Supports. Changed from Opposes on June 12, 2026. View source history.

A changed position is not framed as hypocrisy or growth. The site reports the change and the dates.

09. Technical system architecture

Recommended architecture separates the public web product from collection and research workers. This keeps the voter experience fast even while crawlers and AI jobs run in the background.

Logical architecture

Component	Suggested technology	Responsibility
Public Web App	Next.js + TypeScript	SSR/ISR pages, search, race comparison, voter match, public API.
Public API	Typed server API	Read-only race/candidate/issue endpoints; correction intake.
PostgreSQL	Relational source of truth	Candidates, races, issues, stances, sources, evidence, audits, user-neutral saved preferences if enabled.
Research Worker	Python	Crawling, document extraction, API adapters, source normalization, scheduled research.
Job Queue	Redis-compatible queue	Crawl jobs, source diff jobs, AI extraction, review notifications.
Object Storage	S3-compatible	Permitted snapshots, PDFs, images, transcript artifacts, raw source captures.
Search Index	Postgres FTS initially	Candidate-source passage search; move to OpenSearch only if needed.
AI Adapter	Provider-agnostic service	Structured extraction and classification suggestion.

Admin Console	Protected web app	Research, review, disputes, campaign responses, audit trail.
Observability	Logs + error tracking + metrics	Crawl failures, stale sources, API errors, publication changes.

Deployment recommendation

- Deploy public web separately from worker processes so crawler spikes cannot slow voter pages.
- Use managed PostgreSQL with point-in-time recovery.
- Use object storage outside the application filesystem.
- Use a CDN for public pages and static assets.
- Run workers in a region close to the database, with outbound network access and strict secrets management.
- Pin production dependencies in lockfiles and use staged deployment with rollback.
- Keep platform adapters isolated so X, Meta, YouTube, or other API changes do not require rewriting the research core.

ASCII data flow

Official election data -> Candidate Registry -> Source Discovery -> Crawler/API Adapters

-> Source Store -> Passage Index -> Issue Retriever -> AI Evidence Extractor

-> Rule Checks -> Human Review -> Published Stance -> Public Race Pages

Campaign Response -----^

Correction Intake -----^

10. Data model and API contracts

Core entities

Entity	Key fields
Election	id, name, cycle, general_date, status
Race	id, election_id, office, state, district, seat_class, special_flag
Candidate	id, legal_name, display_name, party_text, fec_candidate_id, incumbent_flag
RaceCandidate	race_id, candidate_id, ballot_status, ballot_order, withdrawn_at
CandidateAccount	candidate_id, platform, account_id, canonical_url, verification_method, status
Issue	id, slug, neutral_title, public_category
IssueVersion	id, issue_id, cycle, canonical_question, goal, plan_json, effective_at
Source	id, candidate_id, type, url, platform_id, published_at, retrieved_at, hash, archive_ref
SourcePassage	id, source_id, start_offset, end_offset, text, embedding_ref

	optional
Evidence	id, candidate_id, issue_version_id, source_passage_id, directness, reviewer_note
Stance	id, candidate_id, issue_version_id, label, effective_at, supersedes_id, status
StanceEvidence	stance_id, evidence_id, weight_order
CampaignResponse	id, candidate_id, issue_version_id, answer, explanation, verified_submitter
CorrectionCase	id, target_type, target_id, submitter_type, state, resolution
AuditEvent	id, actor_id, action, entity_type, entity_id, before_json, after_json, timestamp
ResearchJob	id, candidate_id, issue_version_id optional, source_scope, status, started_at, finished_at

Public API examples

- GET /api/v1/elections/{electionId}/races
- GET /api/v1/races/{raceId}
- GET /api/v1/races/{raceId}/comparison
- GET /api/v1/candidates/{candidateId}
- GET /api/v1/candidates/{candidateId}/stances
- GET /api/v1/issues
- GET /api/v1/issues/{slug}
- GET /api/v1/stances/{stanceId}/evidence
- POST /api/v1/find-races with address or district inputs
- POST /api/v1/corrections
- POST /api/v1/campaign-response with authenticated campaign token

API response principles

- Every stance response includes issue_version_id, label, last_verified_at, evidence_count, and evidence URLs/IDs.
- Public APIs never expose reviewer personal information, private correction contact data, raw voter addresses, or internal model confidence.
- Candidate party is factual metadata. It is never used to compute stance.
- Cache public read endpoints aggressively and invalidate by versioned publication events.

11. Frontend design system and page specifications

Visual direction

The aesthetic should feel closer to a modern public-data product than a campaign site. Use editorial typography, generous space, clear evidence links, and neutral colors. Avoid patriotic cliches, flags as decoration, stars-and-stripes treatments, red-versus-blue split screens, podium imagery, and horse-race graphics.

Token	Recommendation
Base	Warm white or very light gray background.
Primary text	Charcoal / deep slate.
Accent	Muted teal or desaturated cyan, used for navigation and focus.
Support/Oppose chips	Same neutral border and weight. Different text labels, not moral colors.
Typography	Clean sans serif with strong numerals and readable long-form text.
Radius	Small to medium, not playful.
Motion	Minimal. Use only for expanding evidence and compare interactions.
Icons	Simple line icons. Never thumbs up/down for candidate stances.

Home page

- Hero: Where They Stand. 15 questions. Every federal candidate. Their position, their source, your decision.
- Primary action: Find my races.
- Secondary action: Browse the 15 issues.
- Three-step explainer: Find your race, compare positions, inspect sources.
- 15 issue tiles grouped by neutral subject categories, not partisan origin.
- Methodology strip: No endorsements. No party inference. Every stance sourced.
- Recent verified changes module.
- Funding and ownership disclosure link in footer.

Neutral subject categories

Category	Issues
Costs and Markets	Housing Supply; Medical Price Disclosure; Energy Permitting; High-Income and Corporate Minimum Tax
Government and Elections	Congressional Stock Ownership; Federal Voter ID; Federal Voting Access Standards
Immigration and Border	Immigration Reset; Border Enforcement
Rights, Family, and Health	Parental Authority in Schools; Federal Funding for Minor Gender Procedures; Federal Abortion Standard; Universal Health Coverage; Firearm Background Checks
National Security	War Powers

Race comparison page

- Header contains office, state/district, election date, and official election-information link.
- All active ballot candidates receive equal-width headers and the same data fields.
- Default stance table shows issue name plus one text label per candidate.
- Click or tap a stance to open a source drawer with evidence date, source type, short neutral summary, and source link.
- No candidate is placed first because of party. Use official ballot order when available; otherwise alphabetical by surname, with the rule disclosed.
- Mobile view becomes issue-by-issue cards rather than a horizontally squeezed table.
- Optional Compare to Me mode appears only after the voter chooses personal positions.

Personal match mode

- Voter answers Support, Oppose, Different/Unsure, or Skip for each issue.
- Voter may mark up to five issues as Most Important.
- Base agreement: exact match on Support/Oppose. Different Approach is displayed as a non-exact match, not forced into either side.
- Priority agreement shown separately.
- Output language: You agree with Candidate A on 9 of 13 answered questions. You agree with Candidate B on 7 of 13.
- Never output Recommended Candidate, Best Match to America, Most Moderate, or similar site-authored judgment.
- Default to local/session storage so personal political answers need not be sent to the server.

12. Admin and editorial console

Required screens

Screen	Capabilities
Race Registry	Candidate identity, ballot status, official links, account verification.
Research Queue	Unresearched, stale, changed-source, and conflict tasks.
Candidate Corpus	All collected sources with diff view and filters.
Issue Review	Canonical question, retrieved passages, AI proposal, contradictions, prior stance.
Publication History	Every stance version and reviewer action.
Campaign Responses	Verify submitter, review response, publish exact answer.
Corrections	Case intake, evidence, resolution, correspondence, SLA.
Source Health	Dead URLs, robots changes, API errors, deleted posts, snapshot status.
Issue Versions	Locked issue wording and change control.
Audit Log	Search all data changes by actor and entity.

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Roles

Role	Permissions
Researcher	Collect sources, propose evidence. Cannot publish stances.
Reviewer	Approve or reject stance proposals.
Senior Reviewer	Resolve conflicts and material corrections.
Election Data Editor	Manage race/candidate identity and ballot status.
Admin	User access, system settings, issue-version releases.
Read-only Auditor	Inspect source, stance, and audit history without edits.

Editorial SLA targets

- Clear material error: correct as soon as verified.
- Campaign-supplied official answer: review promptly and publish after identity verification.
- Changed candidate source that may affect stance: route to review automatically.
- Dead source link: retain provenance, attempt archive/fallback, flag source health without automatically changing stance.

13. Privacy, security, reliability, accessibility

Voter privacy

- Do not require an account for race lookup or comparison.
- Do not store street addresses by default. Resolve district, then discard the raw address.
- Keep personal stance selections in the browser by default.
- If saved profiles are added later, make storage opt-in and provide delete/export controls.
- Do not sell or share voter issue-preference data for campaign targeting.
- Analytics should avoid recording free-form address fields or exact political answer payloads.

Application security

- MFA for every admin and editor account.
- Role-based access control enforced server-side.
- Short-lived admin sessions with secure cookies, CSRF protections, rate limiting, and audit logs.
- Secrets in managed secret storage, never in the repository.
- Input validation on corrections, campaign responses, search, URLs, and all admin forms.
- HTML sanitization before rendering collected campaign content.
- Outbound crawler protections against SSRF. Deny private network ranges and unsafe schemes.
- Malware scanning for uploaded campaign documents.
- Database backups plus point-in-time recovery.
- Content Security Policy, HSTS, secure headers, dependency scanning, and automated patch workflow.

- Separate public, staging, and production environments.

Reliability

- Public pages should remain available if research workers, social APIs, or AI providers are down.
- Use job retries with exponential backoff and dead-letter queues.
- Use source content hashes to avoid unnecessary reprocessing.
- Nightly integrity checks for orphaned stances, missing evidence, candidate duplicates, and stale race data.
- Graceful degradation: if district lookup fails, offer state and district selector instead of blocking the site.

Accessibility

- Target WCAG 2.2 AA.
- All stance information must be text, never color-only.
- Full keyboard navigation and visible focus states.
- Screen-reader labels for evidence drawers and comparison controls.
- Readable table alternatives on mobile and assistive technology.
- Respect reduced-motion settings.
- Test address lookup, stance selection, and source inspection with keyboard and screen reader.

14. SEO, analytics, observability, and source archiving

SEO

- Server-render race and candidate pages so public information is indexable.
- Stable canonical URLs by candidate ID and race ID.
- Structured metadata for Person, GovernmentOrganization where appropriate, and BreadcrumbList. Avoid misleading political schema claims.
- Unique page titles: Candidate Name - Positions and Sources - Where They Stand.
- State and district index pages with crawlable race links.
- Generate XML sitemaps segmented by candidates, races, issues, and methodology.

Analytics

- Measure page views, race lookups, issue opens, evidence opens, compare completion, and correction submissions.
- Do not create advertising audiences from user political answers.
- Keep event names neutral. Example: stance_evidence_opened, not candidate_convinced.
- Publish a privacy statement that explains whether any third-party analytics are used.

Observability

- Dashboard: source fetch success, queue age, AI extraction failure, review backlog, stale candidate count, public API latency, correction backlog.
- Alert on sudden candidate-source deletion, mass crawl failures, database replication/backup issues, and publication errors.
- Every publish action should emit a structured event with stance ID, old label, new label, source IDs, actor, and timestamp.

Source archival policy

- Keep source URL, title, author/account, publication date, retrieval date, content hash, and evidence offsets permanently.
- Store full content snapshots only where rights and platform rules allow.
- For deleted or edited social posts, retain metadata and permitted evidence necessary to explain why a prior classification existed.
- Do not republish large copyrighted source text. Public evidence drawers should use a short excerpt or neutral paraphrase plus the source link.

15. Repository structure and coding plan

Recommended monorepo

```

/
apps/
  web/          # Next.js public site + admin routes
  worker/       # Python research worker
packages/
  db/           # schema, migrations, generated types
  ui/           # neutral design system
  contracts/    # shared API schemas
  issue-definitions/ # versioned 15 issue JSON/YAML
services/
  collectors/
    web/
    fec/
    congress/
    google-civic/
    x/
    meta/
    youtube/
    bluesky/
  extraction/
  classification/
  source-archive/
infra/
  docker/
  deploy/
  monitoring/
docs/
  methodology/
  editorial/
  api/
  runbooks/
tests/
  fixtures/
  neutrality/
  e2e/

```

Coding standards

- TypeScript strict mode for web and public API code.
- Python type hints and static checks for worker code.
- Database migrations reviewed and reversible.
- Every collector implements the same adapter interface: `discover`, `fetch`, `normalize`, `health_check`.

- Every published stance must pass a database constraint requiring at least one approved evidence record, except Declined to State and No Public Position Found, which require a completed research record.
- Use feature flags for new collectors, new issue versions, and match-mode changes.
- Add fixtures representing candidates from multiple parties and independents to all neutrality tests.

Suggested CI gates

- Lint and type checks.
- Unit tests.
- Database migration validation.
- API contract tests.
- Neutrality invariant tests.
- Source parser fixture tests.
- Accessibility checks on key public pages.
- End-to-end tests for find race, compare, evidence, match, and correction flows.
- Dependency and secret scanning.
- Build and preview deployment before production.

16. QA, acceptance criteria, and launch gates

Neutrality QA

Test	Pass condition
Party swap test	Changing only candidate party leaves stance output unchanged.
Name swap test	Same evidence under a different candidate name produces same proposed label.
Visual parity	Supports and Opposes use equal visual weight and identical component geometry.
Source parity	Same source hierarchy applies to every candidate.
Silence test	No evidence produces No Public Position Found, never Opposes.
Candidate count parity	All ballot-qualified candidates in a race are shown under the same inclusion rule.
Correction parity	Campaign correction process and response fields are identical for all candidates.
Question parity	Every candidate is compared to the same issue version and canonical question.

Launch acceptance criteria

- 100 percent of targeted federal races have official candidate registry data.
- Every active candidate has identity verification and at least one official source-discovery pass.

- Every candidate/issue pair is either classified or explicitly marked No Public Position Found after a completed research pass.
- Every published Supports, Opposes, or Different Approach stance has viewable evidence provenance.
- Campaign correction form works and produces traceable case IDs.
- Race lookup works for addresses and has a manual fallback.
- Personal match mode works without storing answers server-side by default.
- Public pages pass keyboard, mobile, and accessibility checks.
- Admin publication requires authenticated reviewer approval.
- Production backups, rollback, logs, alerts, and source-health monitoring are active.
- Methodology, ownership/funding disclosure, privacy policy, and correction policy are public before launch.

Pre-election freeze policy

Define in advance whether the site will update positions on election day. A defensible default is to continue correcting factual errors at all times, while placing a short timestamp on all stance records so voters can see when each record was last verified.

17. Implementation sequence and backlog

Phase 0 - Lock the rules

- Finalize site name and visual identity.
- Legal review of the 15 issue descriptions and canonical questions.
- Freeze neutrality and evidence policy for the 2026 cycle.
- Define ownership and funding disclosure.
- Choose hosting, analytics, AI provider, and social API budget.

Phase 1 - Data spine

- Create database schema and migrations.
- Build FEC and state election import pipeline.
- Build candidate identity resolver and race registry.
- Build issue-version package.
- Build public race/candidate API.

Phase 2 - Public MVP

- Home, issue pages, race pages, candidate pages, methodology.
- Address/district lookup.
- Static stance records entered through admin.
- Evidence drawer and source links.
- Responsive neutral design system.

Phase 3 - Research automation

- Candidate website discovery and crawler.
- Source normalization and passage index.
- Congress.gov vote/sponsorship adapter.
- Official social adapters in order of access and value.
- AI evidence extraction with structured output.
- Human review queue and publication workflow.

Phase 4 - Campaign and correction loop

- Campaign account verification or signed response tokens.
- 15-question response form.
- Correction cases and public change history.
- Campaign outreach queue and email templates.

Phase 5 - Voter match and national QA

- Browser-local issue answers and priority selection.
- Agreement math and candidate comparison.
- Nationwide candidate coverage audit.
- Neutrality regression suite.
- Accessibility and load testing.
- Launch runbooks and incident procedures.

Priority backlog after launch

- State legislative races using the same framework where laws are relevant.
- Public API for journalists and civic groups.
- Downloadable candidate source packet.
- Issue history across election cycles.
- Multilingual voter interface, with human-reviewed canonical issue translations.
- Independent methodology audit.

18. Reference sources and developer notes

The following official technical sources should be reviewed by the coding team during implementation. API access, quotas, pricing, permissions, and terms can change, so integrations should be isolated behind adapters.

Reference	Why it matters	Developer URL
OpenFEC API	Federal candidate and committee data. Official FEC developer API.	https://api.open.fec.gov/developers/
FEC campaign finance data	Candidate and committee public records.	https://www.fec.gov/data/
Congress.gov API	Bills, members, committees, and House roll-call vote endpoints.	https://api.congress.gov/
Google Civic Information API	Address-based election, contest, candidate, and election-official data during supported elections.	https://developers.google.com/civic-information
Google Civic voterInfoQuery	Contest and candidate information for a voter address during supported elections.	https://developers.google.com/civic-information/docs/v2/elections/voterInfoQuery
Meta Pages API	Official Meta Pages API and Page public-content access documentation.	https://developers.facebook.com/documentation/pages-api
X Developer Platform	Official X API access and current billing model.	https://developer.x.com/

YouTube Data API	Official channel, video, playlist, and search APIs.	https://developers.google.com/youtube/v3/docs
Bluesky / AT Protocol API	Official Bluesky API hosts and AT Protocol patterns.	https://docs.bsky.app/docs/advanced-guides/api-directory

Current implementation notes, August 2026

- OpenFEC exposes an official developer API for federal candidate and committee information.
- Congress.gov exposes API endpoints including House roll-call votes, which can support incumbent evidence when a vote maps directly to an issue.
- Google Civic can return contest and candidate information for supported elections based on a voter address.
- X currently advertises consumption-based developer access, so costs should be monitored rather than hardcoded into the plan.
- Meta public Page access depends on platform permissions and should not be assumed to cover every public candidate post.
- YouTube provides documented APIs for channel and upload discovery.
- Bluesky exposes public AT Protocol APIs suitable for account and post collection.
- Because external platform access changes, the system must work even when one social source is temporarily unavailable.

Final handoff decisions to make before coding

Decision	Recommended default
Public brand	Where They Stand, pending legal/domain check.
Voter-facing issue organization	Neutral subject categories, not partisan buckets.
Candidate ordering	Official ballot order when available; otherwise alphabetical with disclosed rule.
AI publication	Never automatic. Human approval required.
Address retention	Discard raw address after district resolution by default.
Political-answer storage	Browser-local by default.
Social collection	API-first and terms-compliant. Search/manual fallback.
Source excerpts	Short excerpts or neutral paraphrase with link; do not republish large source blocks.
Campaign correction rights	Same process and prominence for every campaign.
Funding disclosure	Public page before launch.

DEFINITION OF DONE

A developer receiving this document should be able to create the repository, database, public pages, research worker, stance workflow, admin review system, correction process, and deployment plan without inventing the editorial rules.